

Art and The Artist

Five questions for discussion

Five questions designed to push past art into the broader problem Theseus is built around: how the appearance of truth gets made, where it actually resides, and what it would take to tell one from the other.

- 1. Where does the artist actually reside?** Rameau composed *Les Cyclopes* in 1724; Grigory Sokolov performs it in 2026, and the performance is unmistakably his. The Caretaker did not so much compose *Everywhere at the End of Time* as design a method — a slow, recursive degradation of his own samples — through which the experience of dementia is reconstructed in the listener. Banksy refuses authorship altogether, and the work continues to function (and, when his shredder fires inside the auction house, function more sharply for the refusal). If an artwork’s value can live in the *choice of method* rather than in any content the artist personally generated, where does the artist actually reside — in the work, in the process, or in the prior choice to use this process and not another? And does locating the artist in any of these places dissolve the figure of “the artist” entirely, or only refine it down to its irreducible core?
- 2. Can the appearance of truth be manufactured by pure gesture?** Barthes argues in *The Reality Effect* that the most realist details in nineteenth-century prose — Flaubert’s barometer, Michelet’s softly-knocking door — refer to nothing in the narrative. They signify only “the real” itself: *we are the real*, the detail announces, and that announcement does the entire work. If the appearance of truth in art can be produced through purely semiotic gesture, with no referent behind it at all, what stops the same mechanism from operating outside art — in journalism, scientific writing, courtroom testimony, AI-generated images, even one’s own first-person sense of which experiences “feel real”? Is the reality effect a contaminant a rigorous methodology should learn to detect and strip out, or a feature of all communication that no methodology can ever entirely escape?
- 3. Are there truths that exist only in artistic form?** Berger argues that the first paint was likely animal blood, the first metaphor was animal, and that the look passing between human and animal across an “abyss of non-comprehension” was constitutive of human consciousness — a knowledge now extinguished by zoos, pets, and industrial agriculture.

The implication is severe: certain truths exist only in their artistic transmission and resist any restatement as propositions. If true, this places a hard ceiling on methodological truth-seeking — some classes of truth lie permanently outside argument and can only be *shown*, not *said*. Should we accept this ceiling, or is the claim “art carries what argument cannot” itself an evasion that smuggles vagueness into precisely the place where rigor most needs to live?

4. **Is the artwork separable from the story told about it?** Curley argues that Abstract Expressionism’s meaning as a symbol of Western freedom was not in the brushstrokes but in the Cold War apparatus that claimed them; American abstraction in fact grew out of socialist politics, and Soviet Socialist Realism out of modernist experimentation. The same canvas, framed by a different institution, would have meant something opposite. If an artwork’s content can be inverted by the discourse around it, where does that content actually reside — in the canvas, in the discourse, or only in the interaction between them? Is there a rigorous test, even in principle, that could ever separate the work from the story we tell about it? And if no such test exists for art, what does that imply about analogous separations we routinely assume can be made — between data and the framing that delivers it, between events and the news cycle that narrates them, between a person and their reputation?
5. **Where does “aura” live, if not in originality or reproduction?** Sokolov has played *Les Cyclopes* hundreds of times, and each performance is unrepeatable. Fred again.. and Bangalter assembled their Alexandra Palace set out of pre-recorded samples and prior material, yet the live event was, again, irreproducible. The Caretaker’s album is fully reproducible, but the encounter takes six and a half hours and reshapes the listener while it plays. Each of these violates the clean distinction Benjamin drew between the singular original and the mechanical copy. If whatever we want to call “aura” — the irreducible difference between one encounter with a work and another — cannot be located either in originality or in reproduction, where does it actually live? And is its existence even an empirical question we could in principle settle, or is it a category our minds project onto the encounter after the fact, much as Barthes’ reality effect is projected onto a barometer?